

PRISM by EOP Media

Personalized Relevant Intelligence Synthesized for Meaning

Transform the Marketing Profession

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Intro paragraph

This post was first published in 2023. The argument has not changed — the marketing profession has an opportunity at every major economic inflection point to define its own evolution rather than wait for the institutions to hand down a new job description. What has changed is the urgency. AI is here. The institutions are already defining what they need. The profession has a choice to make, and the window is shorter than it looks. What follows is the updated argument.

Early in my career, I ghostwrote for technology executives. It is a skill that requires something most people underestimate: not research, not writing ability, but the capacity to see the world from a viewpoint that is not your own and to find language for what someone else is trying to say. It is the work of a translator — not between languages but between thought and expression.

One of the first long-form pieces I wrote for an executive came back looking like someone had taken a brush to a finished painting — every stroke questioned, every color second-guessed, the original composition barely visible underneath the corrections of someone who had not been there when the canvas was blank.

I was not just disappointed. I was shaken — not sure whether the failure was in my writing or in my understanding of what writing for someone else required.

I sought help before sending the next draft. The person I went to was a senior public relations manager — a career advertising professional who had spent decades inside the agency world, Ogilvy and Mather trained, where the creative value of marketing was understood and protected as the product itself. He had come to IBM in the latter part of his career and was generous with his knowledge in the way that people are when they are genuinely invested in passing something on. We reviewed the draft together. He saw the disappointment in how I carried myself. And when we reached the end of the article, he looked at me and asked a question I have never forgotten.

Where was he when the paper was white?

It landed before I understood it. Then it opened everything up. The executive had not been there when there was nothing — no argument, no voice, no draft to react to. He arrived when the work existed and reshaped it according to his preferences. The value of what I had created — the translation from blank page to fully realized perspective — was invisible to him because he had never experienced the absence of it.

The Pattern the Profession Has Lived By

At every major economic inflection point over the past thirty years, the marketing profession has responded the same way: by adjusting to what the institutions decided they needed.

Social media arrived and marketing became community management — building audiences on platforms the institutions did not own and could not control, after marketing professionals had translated the value of what social connection meant for business and individuals had built the communities that proved it. Mobile arrived and marketing became mobile-first strategy, shaped by platform constraints and approved after the value of mobile engagement had already been demonstrated by the practitioners working inside it. The measurement systems changed. The channels changed. The job titles changed. But the underlying pattern did not: the profession identified the shifts, their creation was coopted and redirected to institutional value rather than to economic progress or to professional value for the marketer.

This is a failure of individual marketing professionals and a failure of collective posture. The profession responds to what institutions demand rather than using its collective power to direct economic progress. Not because individual practitioners lack insight — the history of every shift proves they see it first. But because the default has been adjustment rather than assertion, response rather than definition.

The result is visible in how marketing is positioned inside most organizations: a support function rather than a strategic one, brought in after the product is defined to communicate what has already been decided, recognized for execution rather than for the insight and creation that made the execution possible. The practitioner creates the value. Someone else gets the byline.

What AI Is About to Do to This Pattern

AI is not a new tool for the marketing profession to adopt. It is an inflection point at which the pattern either repeats or transforms.

The institutions are already defining what they need. AI-powered content at scale. Automated personalization. Faster production at lower cost. The job descriptions are being rewritten as this is being read — and they are being written by people who are optimizing for efficiency without understanding what they are optimizing away.

What they are optimizing away is the part that cannot be automated: the capacity to see the world from a viewpoint that is not your own, to find language for what someone else is trying to say, to translate between thought and expression in a way that is specific to a particular audience at a particular moment. That is not a feature. It is the core competency of the marketing discipline. And it is the part that AI makes more valuable, not less — because the landscape is now full of content that was produced without it.

The marketing professional who understands this has two choices. Adjust to what the institutions are asking for and become a prompt engineer who scales what has already been decided. Or define what marketing should become at this inflection point and lead that definition before someone else hands it down.

What Leading the Definition Looks Like

PRISM — Personalized Relevant Intelligence Synthesized for Meaning — is EOP Media's answer to what marketing contribution looks like in an AI-mediated landscape. It is not a tool built after the product was defined. It is a methodology that changes when and how the marketing function enters the work.

The traditional marketing posture is: product is defined, strategy is set, marketing communicates. PRISM inverts that. It is embedded in the content itself — a structured approach to helping readers extract personal meaning from information that is moving faster than most content strategies were designed to handle. The marketing intelligence is inside the work, not applied after the fact.

What that means for visibility is significant. Marketing professionals have long done work that gets attributed to the product, the campaign, or the executive who approved it. PRISM creates a mechanism through which the methodology is visible — where the practitioner's contribution to how the audience engages with content is part of the deliverable, not invisible behind it.

That is one model. The specifics are less important than the posture: the profession defining the marketing contribution rather than waiting to be assigned a role in what someone else has already decided.

The Mantle That Gets Passed

The advertising professional who asked "Where was he when the paper was white?" was not just calming my frustrations about a rejected draft. He was passing something on — the understanding that creative contribution has value that critique and redirection do not, that the person who builds something from nothing has standing that the person who reshapes it does not, and that honoring your creative value means recognizing it, naming it, and refusing to let it disappear into someone else's byline.

He had spent a career in an industry that understood this. The great advertising agencies of the twentieth century were built on the premise that creative insight was the product — not the execution of someone else's strategy but the generation of ideas that the strategy followed. That understanding has eroded inside most marketing organizations. The profession let it erode by adjusting rather than insisting.

The inflection point we are standing in is an opportunity to insist — with evidence. With methodologies built before the product is defined. With frameworks that make the marketing contribution visible inside the work rather than attributed to it afterward. With the posture of a discipline that shapes economic shifts rather than responds to them.

The profession has always had the power to define this moment. The question is whether it will.

The Infrastructure This Post Was Reaching For

PRISM — a methodology built by a marketing professional, before the product was defined, that changes when and how the marketing function enters the work.

eopmedia.com/press-release/eop-media-introduces-prism-a-named-methodology-for-the-age-of-ai-mediated-intelligence/

The Agency Collective — the environment where emerging technology assets like PRISM get built, protected, and released on the builder's terms.

eopmedia.com/uncategorized/eop-media-opens-the-agency-collective-a-token-gated-build-environment-where-founders-develop-protect-and-release-the-next-generation-of-intelligence-assets/

These two posts are companion pieces. Evolve Marketing for the Next Economy addresses the discipline itself. This post addresses the people inside it. Each stands independently.

eopmedia.com/big-ideas/evolve-marketing-for-the-next-economy/

PRISM PROMPT CARDS

Choose the prompt that matches your context. Copy it into your AI of choice — Claude, ChatGPT, or Perplexity — and add your specific situation to make the intelligence yours.

IF YOU ARE A MARKETER WATCHING YOUR ROLE GET REDEFINED AROUND YOU

This article argues that marketing professionals consistently do the foundational creative work — translating ideas into language, building audiences, identifying shifts — and then have that contribution absorbed into institutional value without recognition. I want to examine where this pattern is showing up in my current role. Help me identify the specific moments in my workflow where I am creating value that is not being attributed to me, and what it would look like to make that contribution visible rather than invisible.

IF YOU ARE A FOUNDER DECIDING HOW MARKETING FITS INTO YOUR BUILD

The article describes two postures for marketing inside an organization: a support function brought in after the product is defined to communicate what has already been decided, and a strategic function embedded in the work from the beginning. I am building a product and I need to think through which posture I am actually creating — and whether my current structure makes marketing's contribution visible or buries it. Help me map out what early-stage marketing involvement looks like when it is treated as a core competency rather than a communication layer.

IF YOU ARE A GHOSTWRITER OR CONTENT STRATEGIST WHOSE WORK CARRIES SOMEONE ELSE'S NAME

The article opens with the image of a ghostwriter whose draft came back unrecognizable, and a mentor who reframed the experience with a single question: where was he when the paper was white? I want to think through what it means to name and protect the value of origination — the work of translating a blank page into a fully realized perspective — when the professional structure I work in routes attribution away from me. Help me think through how I articulate the value of what I do before the draft exists, not just what I deliver.

IF YOU ARE A MARKETING LEADER BEING ASKED TO IMPLEMENT AI AT SCALE

The article argues that institutions are currently optimizing AI adoption for efficiency — content at scale, automated personalization, faster production at lower cost — and that what gets optimized away is the capacity to translate between thought and expression in ways specific to a particular audience at a particular moment. I am being asked to lead AI adoption for my team and I want to do it without eroding the core competency the article is describing. Help me think through what AI implementation looks like when it is designed to amplify human marketing judgment rather than replace it.

IF YOU ARE BUILDING A METHODOLOGY OR FRAMEWORK AND WANT TO RELEASE IT AS YOURS

The article describes PRISM as a methodology built by a marketing professional before the product was defined — and positions that sequence as the thing that makes the contribution visible rather than absorbed. I am developing my own framework or methodology and I want to think through how to structure and release it in a way that keeps my name and perspective attached to it. Help me think through what it means to build something before the institutional context exists for it, and how to protect that origination as the framework moves into the world.

IF YOUR SITUATION IS DIFFERENT FROM ANY OF THE ABOVE

The article is about a pattern — the marketing profession adjusting to what institutions demand rather than defining what the discipline should become at each inflection point. My situation is this: [describe your role, what you are building or navigating, and what the AI inflection point looks like from where you sit]. Help me think through where this pattern shows up in my specific context and what asserting rather than adjusting could look like for me.

WANT A PERSONALIZED VERSION?

Members of The Agency Collective access PRISM Standard — prompt cards generated from your specific profile: your business stage, your goals, your fluency level. Learn more at <https://eopmedia.com/the-agency-collective/>